Listing 3.3 The {% lorem %} tag with arguments in the Django REPL

```
>>> t = Template("{% lorem 5 w %}")
>>> t.render(Context({}))
'lorem ipsum dolor sit amet'
```

Tags are kind of like functions, and like functions, the choice of arguments is specific to the tag. Some tags interpret their arguments as the names of variables, while others, like `{% lorem %}`, take them verbatim. You'll see the difference as you learn a few of the more common tags in the next section.

3.5 Common tags and filters

Although Django comes with many tags and filters, there are a few that you will find you use over and over again. Let's cover a few you're likely to use while building RiffMates.

3.5.1 Conditional blocks

It was probably early on in your programming journey when you first came across the need for `if` statements. You'll find the same need in templates. The basic conditional statement is a block, which means it uses paired tags: `{% if %}` and `{% endif %}`.

The `{% if %}` tag takes a condition, which if true means the block gets rendered. The simplest condition is the name of a variable. In this case, the variable gets evaluated for "truthiness," following the same rules as `if` statements in Python. The following renders the `<h1>` content if `first_page` evaluates to `True`:

```
{% if first_page %}
    <h1> Welcome to <i>RiffMates</i> </h1>
{% endif %}
```

If `first_page` contains zero, `False`, an empty container (`list`, `set`, `dict`, etc.), or doesn't exist in the context, the block gets excluded from the render. All other values of `first_page` result in the enclosing block getting shown.

Block tags generally don't care about newlines or spacing. The `{% if %}` and `{% endif %}` tags can appear on the same line. I frequently have a conditional block in my `<title>` tag, optionally appending a page name to a default shorter title:

```
<title>RiffMates{% if title_suffix %} &mdash; {{title_suffix}}
➥ {% endif %}</title>
```

The `{% if %}` tag supports the same comparison operators as Python. You can use `==`, `!=`, `<`, `>`, `<=`, `>=`, `in`, `not in`, `is`, and `is not` to compare variables or values. Comparing the value of `num_drummers` to a constant is similar to Python:

```
{% if num_drummers > 1 %}
    <b>You only need one drummer!</b>
{% endif %}
```